Régis Renault: From Brancaille to Modern Pankration

Written by Lukas Roth

In France, Régis Renault is often described as the father of modern pankration and as one of the forerunners of contemporary MMA. His name is also closely associated with Marseille Brancaille, an old and popular form of bare-knuckle fighting that was practiced for many years outside the established sporting institutions, as well as with various alternative circles and strands of esoteric spirituality that influenced parts of his life and career.

Born in 1962, according to the accounts generally reported about him, Régis Renault first began to make a name for himself as a teenager. It was during this period that he met Ernest Banon, a controversial figure who taught Brancaille to young people, some of them from troubled backgrounds and searching for a sense of direction. Through Banon and his teachings, Renault discovered an approach to fighting that was far removed from codified sporting disciplines: a practice based above all on effectiveness, adaptability, close-quarters combat, and a certain street-fighting culture.

His independent temperament, his choice of associates, and his strong attraction to confrontation soon led him into unsavory circles. He became involved in street fights and violent confrontations on several occasions. This period helped build his reputation, but it would later prove to be a major obstacle when he sought official recognition for his teaching.

It was in this context that he became interested in Indian martial arts and became a student of Suresh Mukerjee, better known as Sri Vajtahan. Under the guidance of this master, Renault deepened his knowledge of India's martial and spiritual traditions, eventually becoming one of his assistants.

A Turning Point: From the Streets to Teaching

In 1988, an accident during a fight marked a turning point in his life. Following the incident, Renault gradually distanced himself from street fighting and increasingly devoted himself to study, writing, and the teaching of martial arts.

This period played a decisive role in the development of his thinking. Fighting gradually ceased to be viewed simply as a physical confrontation and became, for him, a means of exploring the body, willpower, and inner discipline.

Renault then began working on a project that went far beyond martial arts training: creating a place where disadvantaged young people and those who had fallen outside traditional social structures could be welcomed and supported. The aim was to provide an environment in which physical training, learning, and mentorship could serve as tools for personal and social reconstruction.

Sri Vajtahan, however, was reluctant to see him teach Indian martial arts. Renault was therefore faced with the need to develop a system of his own—a situation made all the more complicated by the fact that he was regarded as one of the heirs to Ernest Banon's Brancaille school. In theory, this lineage would have given him the legitimacy to pass the art on; in practice, the controversial reputation surrounding Brancaille and some of its practitioners threatened to undermine his plans to use martial arts as a means of helping young people reintegrate into society.

It was out of this tension between inheritance and the desire for a clean break that his project for a modern form of pankration gradually emerged.

Reconstructing Ancient Pankration

Passionate about antiquity and the history of fighting systems, Renault became interested in the origins of martial arts and in ancient forms of wrestling and all-out combat. He then set out to reconstruct what a contemporary form of ancient pankration might have looked like, drawing in particular on Marseille Brancaille and Vajra Mushti Yuddha, an Indian martial tradition based on close-quarters combat.

This approach gradually led him to delve deeper into the history of ancient pankration. His historical research was not limited to studying texts; it was accompanied by a desire to physically test techniques that he believed could be identified in ancient representations. Together with his students and collaborators, he experimented with various hypotheses and attempted to connect archaeological sources with technical knowledge derived from Brancaille and Indian martial arts.

Modern pankration thus took shape at the crossroads of several influences: Marseille Brancaille, the experience acquired through street fighting, Vajra Mushti, and the study of ancient martial traditions. It was therefore not a discipline born from a rejection of his past, but rather the result of a gradual synthesis between practical martial experience and years of research.

Over time, other influences enriched the project. Practitioners and experts from a range of different martial disciplines became involved with Renault and helped broaden the technical scope of his teaching.

Institutional Obstacles

The project soon encountered numerous obstacles. At the time, French authorities and much of the sporting establishment were particularly wary of forms of full-contact fighting. The very notion of a “combat sport” was still largely associated with disciplines that had already been institutionalized and placed under the authority of recognized federations. Pankration, with its combination of striking, throws, joint locks, and ground fighting, was difficult to fit into the existing categories.

This institutional suspicion was compounded by Renault's troubled past, his former associations, and the reputation of some of the circles with which he was connected. For someone attempting to turn fighting into a tool for education and social integration, this image represented a particularly difficult contradiction to overcome.

Renault, however, was known for being tenacious, stubborn, and unwilling to give up in the face of adversity. Lacking official facilities, he began teaching wherever he could: outdoors, in the scrubland around Marseille, on vacant lots, and in stadiums. Conditions were often rudimentary, and training sessions sometimes went ahead regardless of the weather. This nomadic approach helped shape the identity of the first groups that gathered around him.

He also found support among other practitioners and educators who had themselves been marginalized by local institutions and denied access to sports halls and facilities. Together, they gradually managed to rent a space and organize regular training sessions. Seminars and training camps were then held, first locally and later on a national scale, allowing the discipline to gradually gain recognition beyond its Marseille birthplace.

The movement began to expand beyond its original circle of followers. Practitioners from other martial arts backgrounds took an interest and contributed to its development. Renault's vision of pankration thus gradually evolved into a hybrid discipline, drawing on several fighting traditions while explicitly seeking to revive a more comprehensive approach to combat.

Controversy and Withdrawal

This development was not without controversy. In 1999, Régis Renault's past suddenly resurfaced in an article published by an association-run newspaper and signed by a man named Bertrand Boyer. The publication reignited questions about his background, his former associations,

and the origins of the movement he led, further weakening his position within the organization.

Renault eventually stepped down as president. A few years later, in 2003, he broke definitively with pankration and, more broadly, with the martial arts world.

This break marked the end of an important period in his life. After several decades devoted to fighting, teaching, and martial research, Régis Renault chose instead to focus primarily on writing, historical research, and his spiritual quest.

His life story is therefore marked by a succession of breaks and transformations: from the streets to martial discipline, from Brancaille to Indian traditions, and ultimately from physical combat to writing and spiritual research.

Whether he is regarded as a pioneer of modern pankration, a controversial figure, or a representative of an era when the boundaries between martial arts, counterculture, and alternative practices were still particularly fluid, his story remains inseparable from the lesser-known history of combat sports in France. Above all, he represents a generation of practitioners who, long before the professionalization and media exposure of MMA, were already seeking to bring striking, wrestling, ground fighting, and a broader conception of combat together within a single practice.